

THE COMPETITORS

◀ GANAPATI P. RAJKUMAR, 58, DMK

A former AIADMK leader from Coimbatore, he was elected councillor in 2001 and served as the mayor from 2014 to 2016. Owing to differences with the party leadership, he shifted to the DMK in 2020. Has a PhD in mass communication

▼ SINGAI G. RAMACHANDRAN, 36, AIADMK

An engineering graduate and IIM Ahmedabad alumnus, he has been associated with the party's IT wing since 2016 and was appointed its president in 2023. His father, Singai Govindarasu, was an AIADMK legislator from Coimbatore's Singanallur seat in the 1990s



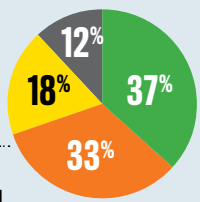
In the past two elections, the BJP has managed a second spot in Coimbatore. Can the party's TN chief and party candidate here better that?

LS 2014

● Winner
P. NAGARAJAN
AIADMK

● Runner-up
C.P. RADHAKRISHNAN
BJP

● 2nd runner-up
K. GANESHKUMAR
DMK



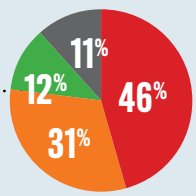
AIADMK had contested the 2014 Lok Sabha polls independently

LS 2019

● Winner
P.R. NATARAJAN
CPI(M)

● Runner-up
C.P. RADHAKRISHNAN
BJP

● 2nd runner-up
R. MAHENDRAN
MNM#



In 2019, CPI(M) and Congress were part of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance

Figures denote vote share and are rounded off ● *Others* #MNM: Makkal Needhi Maiam

Hindutva vision saying, "Of course, the question of identity and ideology matters, but it has to be done in combination with other goals." The lack of a strong cadre base is a big drawback that could hinder the BJP's quest. Annamalai is also being blamed for not taking veteran state leaders along. A party insider says, "He is still behaving like an IPS officer, using command and control techniques when he should be assuaging and persuading his team and state leaders."

What apparently stumped Annamalai was the BJP's insistence that he contest the Coimbatore seat,

THE BJP'S TAMIL NADU STRATEGY IS TO RAISE THE VOTE PERCENTAGE TO A LEVEL WHERE IT DETHRONES THE AIADMK AS THE PRIME CHALLENGER OF THE DMK

something he was reluctant to do as he wanted to devote his energies to managing the party's overall campaign in the state. His first attempt at contesting an assembly election seat at Arvakuchi ended in failure, but pollsters says he is putting up a good fight this time. Annamalai is up against tough competition. The AIADMK has put up the young Singai Ramachandran, who also has an engineering degree and IIM background. The DMK has fielded Ganapati Rajkumar, a former mayor of Coimbatore who was earlier with the AIADMK. All three belong to the Gounder community and the contest is expected to be a close race.

Annamalai, though, remains confident of coming through. At the fag end of the day's campaign when he stopped for a quick snack at a supporter's house, INDIA TODAY asked him about the difference between being a policeman and a politician. His reply was pat, "It's a lot more hard work than being in the force. There, you would read the law, see it in black and white and then put it into action. In politics, you have to take everybody along, calculate the short- and long-term gains. It's always a balance. The Greek historians used to call politics the result of the original sin. It's a great learning.... I am like a toddler learning how to walk." But once on his feet, there is no doubt that Annamalai will travel far. ■